context of Sino-Soviet friction. Moreover, India needed help to tackle the China threat, which would "continue for some generations." And the US and UK were willing to assist without asking India to give up nonalignment. Thus, while it was important to continue to try to separate Beijing from Moscow, India had "to be careful not to cut across the pattern of friendly relations" with the US and others who had been helpful.[13]

There was indeed support in the US for aiding India against the China threat. Kennedy let Nehru know that the US, along with the UK, remained prepared to assist India with its defense needs.[14] Former president Eisenhower called for "all-out American military assistance to India," but only if the US was "determined to go as far as we must." He was concerned that some would take a narrow "I told you so" view and argue against aid to India.[15] And there were skeptics. For example, Senator Richard Russell (D-GA), then chairman of the Armed Services Committee, opposed military assistance because of doubts about Indian capacity and reliability.[16]

Having been taken by surprise by the war itself, American officials were concerned about China suddenly resuming hostilities.[17] They believed, however, that there were limits to the responsibilities that the US could or should undertake—partly because of limited resources. Thus, while Kennedy asserted that the US would continue to cooperate with India and give it advice and support, he made clear that the primary responsibility was Indian.[18] Washington was also keen that the Commonwealth take the lead on questions like coordinated air assistance.[19]

At their December 1962 summit in the Caribbean, Kennedy and British prime minister Harold Macmillan discussed how to help India better defend itself against the Chinese threat.[20] Each side agreed to provide up to $60 million of military assistance and, furthermore, explore a plan for air defense.[21] They also decided to consider defense production assistance. In addition, US agencies initiated a training program to help Indian forces combat potential guerrilla operations in India's border areas. Furthermore, the US focused more intelligence assets on the Chinese threat to India.[22] During the war, Nehru had allowed U-2s to refuel in and overfly Indian airspace for reconnaissance of the China border. Overflights from a US facility in Thailand commenced that December and would continue in 1963, with Nehru being briefed on the intelligence acquired. A June 1963 agreement would also permit the use of an Indian base at Charbatia. U-2